Footprints without Feet

The big idea

Footprints without Feet is an extract adapted from **H.G. Wells's** novel *The Invisible Man*. It tells how **Griffin**, a brilliant scientist who discovers how to make his body **invisible**, misuses his discovery and becomes a **lawless** man. It raises the question: what happens when science is used without ethics?

Summary

1. **The footprints:** Two boys in a London square are puzzled to see **fresh muddy footprints** appearing on the steps of a house — but no one is making them. They follow the prints until they fade away. The invisible **Griffin** is walking barefoot.
2. **The discovery:** Griffin had found a way to make the human body **transparent** by swallowing certain rare drugs. He became invisible — but his clothes remained visible, so he had to go about **naked** in the cold.
3. **Burning the house:** His landlord disliked him and tried to eject him; in revenge, Griffin **set fire to the house** and fled.
4. **In the London store:** To keep warm, he slipped into a big London **department store** after closing time. He ate, slept in a pile of quilts and dressed in warm clothes. In the morning the assistants found him; he had to throw off the clothes and run away, naked again.
5. **Drury Lane:** He went to a **theatrical company's shop** in Drury Lane, hit the shopkeeper from behind and stole **bandages, dark glasses, a false nose, whiskers and a large hat**, plus money, so he could appear in public.
6. **At Iping:** Disguised, he took rooms at the inn in the village of **Iping** run by **Mrs Hall**. He said he wanted to be left alone. His strange appearance, wrapped in

bandages, made the villagers curious; he paid well, which kept Mrs Hall quiet for a while.

7. **The robbery:** Early one morning the **clergyman and his wife** heard noises in the study and found their money gone — but no one was in the room. Griffin had robbed them.
8. **The flying furniture:** The same morning Mr and Mrs Hall found Griffin's room empty, his clothes and bandages lying about. Suddenly a hat flew at Mrs Hall's face and a **chair** pushed them out of the room. Mrs Hall thought the furniture was bewitched ("spirits").
9. **The escape:** When Griffin returned, the villagers asked for an explanation. Angry, he pulled off his nose, bandages and whiskers — revealing a **headless** figure. The constable **Jaffers** tried to arrest him; Griffin threw off his clothes, became fully invisible, fought off his attackers and **escaped**.

SCIENCE WITHOUT ETHICS

Griffin is a **genius** but **lawless** and **selfish**. Instead of using his discovery for good, he burns a house, robs shops and a clergyman, attacks people and causes fear.

Character of Griffin

- Brilliant scientist, inventive.
- Hot-tempered, impatient, short of money.
- Selfish, unscrupulous and violent — a criminal.

INVISIBLE BODY, VISIBLE CLOTHES

Griffin became invisible only when **naked**; his clothes and bandages could be seen. That is why he wore disguises and why the footprints were bare.

Themes and value points

- Science is a double-edged sword; discoveries need moral responsibility.
- Power without values leads to misuse.
- Curiosity of ordinary people (the boys, the villagers) and their fear of the unknown.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

How did Griffin become invisible? Why did he go to the London store and Drury Lane? What happened at Iping? Why did the clergyman and his wife not see the thief? Describe Griffin as a "lawless person".

Quick recap

- H.G. Wells; Griffin, the invisible man.
- Footprints in London; burnt landlord's house; London store; Drury Lane disguise.
- Iping inn (Mrs Hall); clergyman robbed; flying furniture; Jaffers; escape.
- Theme: misuse of science; genius without ethics.

Practice questions

1. How did Griffin become invisible?

   (a) By wearing a magic cloak (b) By swallowing certain rare drugs (c) By standing in sunlight (d) By a spell

2. Why did Griffin set fire to his landlord's house?

   (a) To keep warm (b) To hide his experiments (c) In revenge, because the landlord tried to eject him (d) By accident

3. What did Griffin get from the theatrical shop in Drury Lane?

   (a) Food and medicine (b) Bandages, dark glasses, false nose, whiskers and a hat (c) A coat and boots only (d) A gun

4. Who ran the inn at Iping?

   (a) Jaffers (b) The clergyman (c) Mrs Hall (d) Mr Bunting's wife

5. What did Mrs Hall think when the furniture attacked her?

   (a) Burglars were hiding (b) There was an earthquake (c) It was a joke by the boys (d) The furniture was possessed by spirits

6. Who tried to arrest Griffin?

   (a) The clergyman (b) Constable Jaffers (c) Mr Hall (d) The two boys

7. Griffin was invisible only when

   (a) he was in the dark (b) he was sleeping (c) he had no clothes on (d) he was wet

8. Griffin was a brilliant scientist but a lawless person. Justify.

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. b 4. c 5. d 6. b 7. c 8. see notes